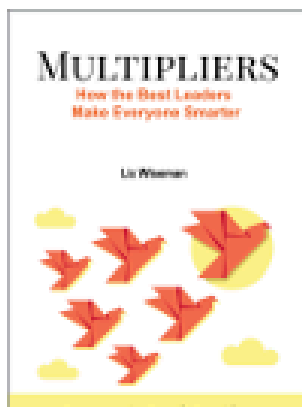




MULTIPLIERS

How the Best Leaders Make Everyone Smarter

LIZ WISEMAN



The Big “So What”

Why do some leaders create a positive impact on people around them while others don't? This book presents the characteristics of Multipliers who amplify the results of people around them (vs Diminishers who reduce others' results). It also lays out practical tips, experiments and steps you can take to become a Multiplier and build a Multiplier culture.



Introduction: The Multiplier Effect



Based on research of more than 150 executives across 4 continents, Wiseman discovered that **leaders can be placed on a spectrum between two extremes: Multipliers vs Diminishers**.

- Multipliers are leaders who bring out others' capability and intelligence. They're "genius makers" who multiply an organization's collective intelligence.
- Diminishers are leaders who're so absorbed in their own genius that they stifle others', thus depleting the organization's vital intellectual resources.



Wiseman's research found that managers used on average only 66% of their people's capability. Interestingly, **Multipliers get 2x more out of people than Diminishers**.

- Multipliers concurrently extract and expand people's intelligence. People around Multipliers feel like winners. They're inspired to give 100% of their creativity/effort and to stretch themselves beyond their original capacity. By contrast, people around Diminishers get their ideas squashed until they eventually shut down or quit.

KEY QUOTES

This book will show you why [Multipliers] create genius around them and make everyone smarter and more capable."

"It isn't how much you know that matters. What matters is how much access you have to what other people know. It isn't just how intelligent your team members are; it is how much of that intelligence you can draw out and put to use."

This book will show you why [Multipliers] create genius around them and make everyone smarter and more capable."

- Multipliers adopt the *Logic of Multiplication*. They recognize that you can multiply results by leveraging existing capabilities instead of adding new ones. Diminishers adopt the Logic of Addition which assumes a linear relationship between resources and output. They may get the job done, but with a huge waste of resources.



The 5 Disciplines of Multipliers



The difference between Multipliers and Diminishers come from their difference in mindsets. Diminishers assume that people can't figure things out without them, while Multipliers assume that people are smart and can work things out. **Such assumptions drive their behaviors differently in 5 key ways.**

	 MULTIPLIERS	DIMINISHERS 
ASSUMPTION	"People are smart and can figure things out."	"People can't figure it out without me."
BEHAVIORS / DISCIPLINES	 Talent Magnets Hire talented people, use/develop them fully, and help them to succeed. People thrive and a Cycle of Attraction is created.	 Empire Builders Hire talented people but underutilize them. Hoard resources for own gain. Talents are stunted, results suffer, and a Cycle of Decline is created.
	 Liberators Create an intense environment that demands people's best performance. They create stability so people are free to think/act boldly and focus on their work.	 Tyrants Create a tensed environment that crushes people's ability to think/perform. They create anxiety so people act cautiously and are afraid to speak up.
	 Challengers Define opportunities in a way that motivates people to stretch themselves beyond existing know-how, discover and execute optimal solutions.	 Know-it-Alls Define directives, show off their superior insights and tell people what to do. People second-guess the boss and are stuck with what they already have/know.
	 Debate Makers Engage people in rigorous debate to arrive at sound decisions. People are challenged, own and understand the decisions made.	 Decision Makers Make decisions by themselves or their inner circle, dominate discussions and force through decisions, leaving others feeling uninvolved and confused.
	 Investors Investors build people's ownership and ability to perform without them. They share insights but give back the accountability.	 Micromanagers Diminishers try to do everything personally. They jump in and out, creating confusion and overdependence on them.
RESULTS	Get 2X results out of people	Get <50% results out of people

KEY QUOTES



1. The Talent Magnet: Attract and optimize talent



Empire Builders vs Talent Magnets. Both Multipliers and Diminishers seek to attract A-players, i.e. great people with the required talents and abilities for the job. However, they manage these talents differently to create a *self-perpetuating cycle*:

- Diminishers act like Empire Builders. They hoard resources and underutilize talents. They bring in top talent to make themselves look good and build their own career, carve out fiefdoms and position themselves as the sole integrator and decision-maker. The A-players are underutilized, their talents stunted, and the team's performance suffers. As word spreads, it gets harder to attract good people and a *Cycle of Decline* is created.
- Multipliers are Talent Magnets. They hire talented people, use and develop their strengths fully, and remove obstacles to help people succeed. Both the individuals and team thrive, word spreads that they're the best bosses to work for, and more talents flock to them to create a *Cycle of Attraction*.



Talent Magnets attract and nurture talents with 4 practices.

- They look for diverse talent everywhere. Specifically, they:
 - (i) *Value all types of talents* (e.g. quantitative analysis, creative problem-solving); and
 - (ii) *Ignore organizational boundaries* to seek talents inside and outside the organization.
- They find and unlock people's native abilities, be it a knack for connecting people or diagnosing complex issues. They:
 - (i) Carefully observe people to *identify what's native* to them, i.e. things that people do (a) easily without conscious effort and (b) freely without condition.
 - (ii) *Label the ability* to make it obvious. Talents often don't realize their own genius. Labeling it raises their awareness, confidence and the likelihood that they'll use it.

KEY QUOTES

"The Diminisher is an Empire Builder who acquires resources and then wastes them. The Multiplier is a Talent Magnet who utilizes and increases everyone's genius."

"[Diminishers] actively acquire talent, but then are passive about growing it."

"Talent Magnets live in a world without walls and without hierarchical or lateral restrictions. Instead, they see talent networks."

"Finding someone's native genius is a key that unlocks discretionary effort. It propels people to go beyond what is required and to offer their full intelligence."

- They utilize people to the fullest. Specifically, they:
 - (i) *Connect people with opportunities* to use their native ability.
 - (ii) *Shine a spotlight on them* so others can see them in action. This builds their character and confidence even further.
- They remove blockers that hinder people's growth/success:
 - (i) *Remove prima donnas* who persistently put their egos over the team's interests (thus hurting team effectiveness).
 - (ii) *Get out of the way* if they themselves are the blockers.

 To become a Talent Magnet, start by (i) becoming a genius watcher and (ii) weeding out people who're bad for the team. Try these 3 experiments:

- Name the genius: Find the native genius of every team member. Or, consider someone hard to work with and ask "in what way is this person smart?"
- Upsize their role. Give people a role/project that's slightly bigger than their current capabilities, and let them grow into it.
- Let superstars go. When people have outgrown their roles, encourage them to move on. Don't keep them for your own gain. At the same time, don't wait to remove people who're bad for the team.



2. The Liberator: *Demand people's best thinking and effort*



Tyrants vs Liberators. Diminishers use their hierarchical position to suppress others. Multipliers free people to think, speak up and do their best work.

- Diminishers are Tyrants who create a tensed environment that crushes people's ability to think and perform. They insist on their views, shut out others' ideas, dominate the space, and create anxiety by constantly judging others. People are afraid to speak up and act cautiously to avoid coming under fire.

KEY QUOTES

"Removing a highly intelligent employee or leader can be difficult, but it can have huge payoffs...You may lose one mind, but you gain back five. It is a law of numbers."

"The Diminisher is a Tyrant who creates a stressful environment. The Multiplier is a Liberator who creates a safe environment that fosters bold thinking."

- Multipliers are Liberators who create an intense environment that demands people's best performance. They're hard on the issues but easy on the people. They provide the stability for people to focus on their work, and make it safe for people to be bold in their thinking and actions.



Liberators balance between the duality of giving people space and demanding their best effort with 3 practices:

- They create space for people to perform. They:
 - (i) Deliberately *restrain themselves so others can shine*. They guide others to succeed instead of jumping in to do the work.
 - (ii) *Listen avidly* with a deep desire to understand and learn from others. In a typical conversation, they spend 80% listening or asking questions instead of talking.
 - (iii) *Define a space for discovery*, i.e. specify projects or boundaries within which people can take risks freely.
 - (iv) *Level the playing field* so it's easier for disadvantaged parties (e.g. junior staff or people from other teams) to be heard.
- Liberators don't stop at beating a rival or meeting a deadline; they demand the best work from their people. They:
 - (i) *Uphold the standard* by constantly asking "Did you give you best?" or "Is this your best work?"
 - (ii) *Separate best effort from outcomes*, i.e. hold people accountable to their best work instead of insisting on a fixed outcome (which may be beyond their control).
- Create fast learning cycles by learning from mistakes. They:
 - (i) Openly *admit and share their mistakes*, making it safe for others to also take risks and fail, e.g. they may tell stories about their failures and what they learned in the process.

KEY QUOTES

"An unsafe environment yields only the safest ideas... People's best thinking must be given, not taken."

"How smart you are is defined by how clearly you can see the intellect of others."
—C. K. Prahalad

"As a leader, you have to do more than just not discourage it, you need to actively encourage people to speak up."

"Asking whether people are offering their best gives them the opportunity to push themselves beyond previous limits."

"The highest quality of thinking cannot emerge without learning. Learning can't happen without mistakes."

- (ii) *Insist on learning from mistakes*, i.e. it's ok to make mistakes but not make them twice. They invite feedback to improve.

 To become a Liberator, try these experiments:

- *Play your chips*. Give yourself a few poker chips, each worth a different amount of talk-time (e.g. 30s, 90s, 120s). Use these to budget your talk-time at each meeting, so you're forced to choose your contributions wisely and leave space for others.
- People often can't tell if a leader is sharing a casual thought or a policy decision. *Label your opinions* to distinguish soft opinions (meant for further consideration/debate) versus hard opinions (firm views on a vital issue).
- *Share your mistakes*, making it safe for others to experiment and learn from mistakes: (i) Get personal by sharing the mistakes you made and what you learned, and (ii) go public by creating forums where everyone can learn regularly.
- *Make space for mistakes*. Define an area or project where it's ok to experiment and fail without hurting the organization.



3. *The Challenger: Extend compelling challenges*



Know-It-Alls vs Challengers. In setting the direction for their team:

- Diminishers are *Know-It-Alls*. They tell you their superior insights, ask questions to “test” you, and tell you exactly how to do your job. People waste energy second-guessing them or pretending to follow their instructions, and the organization is stuck with what it already has/ knows.
- Multipliers are *Challengers*. They identify the right opportunities, then challenge everyone to get there. They seed ideas and let people stretch themselves to find the solutions. Matt McCauley assessed that Gymboree's share price could be increased from \$0.69 per share to \$1.

KEY QUOTES

“The Diminisher is a Know-It-All who gives directives. The Multiplier is a Challenger who defines opportunities.”

Even though he knew what could be done, he chose to share his “Mission Impossible” and enlist his managers to come up with *their* Mission Impossible. One year later, Gymboree reached \$1.19 per share. Matt kept lifting the bar to reach \$2.15 per share in 2007, then \$3.21 in 2008.



Challengers tap on the entire organization’s abilities with 3 practices:

- They seed the opportunity by asking good questions and giving just enough info to stretch people’s thinking. They:
 - (i) *Show the need by finding ways* for people to see/discover the problem themselves. Once people understand an issue, it’s easier to find solutions.
 - (ii) *Challenge assumptions* by asking questions that disrupt the prevailing logic. Management guru C.K. Prahalad used a fictitious article about Philips’ bankruptcy (at a time when the company seemed invincible) to spark debate on what could cause their downfall.
 - (iii) *Reframe problems* to show new opportunities. When Alan Lafley (former P&G CEO) redefined innovation from “not invented here” to “proudly invented elsewhere”, it opened up new partnership possibilities.
 - (iv) Offer a *starting point* instead of giving the solution. By sparking people’s curiosity and imagination, you can create even bigger/better outcomes.
- Challengers lay down an intriguing challenge that motivates people to stretch and find answers they don’t yet have. They:
 - (i) *Extend a concrete challenge* to help others visualize what the organization must deliver.
 - (ii) *Ask hard questions* that push people to think deeply, realize the gap in their knowledge/abilities, and seek to close the gap.
 - (iii) Back off to *let others fill in the blanks*. They let people think for themselves and take ownership of the problem.

KEY QUOTES

“Once a leader accepts that he or she doesn’t have to have all the answers, he or she is free to ask much bigger, more provocative, and, frankly, more interesting questions. They can pursue things they don’t know how to do.”

“Multipliers don’t give answers. Instead they begin a process of discovery.”

“Multipliers analyze problems, but they also reframe them to show the opportunity presented by the challenges.”

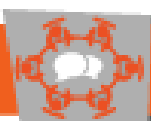
“Diminishers give answers. Good leaders ask questions. Multipliers ask the really hard questions.”

- They create belief that the challenge is achievable, so people will actually take action. They:
 - (i) *Helicopter down to reality* by showing a viable path and why it's possible to achieve an ambitious goal.
 - (ii) Get people to *cocreate the plan* so they'll have greater belief and ownership.
 - (iii) *Orchestrate small, early wins* to build confidence.



To become a Challenger, try these experiments:

- Take the "Extreme Questions Challenge" by speaking to your children or colleagues only in questions. Once you're comfortable to lead with questions, balance it with your natural style.
- Set your team a stretch challenge, e.g. How can we achieve X by Y date, with only Z resources? Then, step back and let them solve it.
- Take a field trip, i.e. bring people offsite for first-hand learning experiences, e.g. see how the poor really live, or watch how a customer uses your product.
- Take a huge baby step. Involve the entire organization in a small win, e.g. use a cross-functional task force to win back a vital customer. Make it visible to build belief organization-wide.



4. The Debate Maker: Debate decisions constructively



Decision Makers vs Debate Makers. Diminishers tend to make decisions by themselves (or with a privileged few), while Multipliers engage people in meaningful.

- Diminishers are Decision Makers. They assume that only a few people are worth listening to. They raise issues, dominate the discussions with their own opinions, and make snap decisions without explaining the rationale. Others in the organization end up feeling confused and left out.

KEY QUOTES

"The number one difference between a Nobel Prize winner and others is not IQ or work ethic, but that they ask bigger questions."
—Peter Drucker

"Multipliers create a meaningful proof point that a bold challenge can be successfully met."

"Diminishers are Decision Makers who try to sell their decisions to others. Multipliers are Debate Makers who generate real buy-in."

- Multipliers are Debate Makers. They bring people together, draw out what they know, and facilitate rigorous debate. They stretch people, depersonalize decisions, and make sound decisions which people own, understand and can execute.

 Multipliers spark constructive debate with 3 practices.

- They frame the issue clearly so people know where to focus and are given time to prepare for the discussion. They specify:
 - (i) *What* is the decision to be made (ideally, specify 2 options instead of a vague topic);
 - (ii) *Why* it's important to resolve the issue;
 - (iii) *Who* will be involved in the decision-making; and
 - (iv) *How* will the final decision be made, e.g. by majority vote, consensus or a single person.
- They spark a debate that's engaging, comprehensive, fact-based and educational. They concurrently:
 - (i) *Create safety* by removing factors that'd cause people to hold back (e.g. sharing their views last); and
 - (ii) *Demand rigor* by encouraging all points of view, focusing on facts/evidence and depersonalizing the issues.
- They focus on the goal and drive a sound decision. They:
 - (i) *Reclarify the decision-making process* by summarizing the key ideas/outcomes and the next steps.
 - (ii) *Make the decision* if consensus isn't possible or necessary.
 - (iii) *Communicate* the decision and rationale.

 Become a Debate Maker by using "shared inquiry":

- Ask the hard question that'll tackle the root of an issue and confront underlying assumptions. Stop and let the team discuss.

KEY QUOTES

"It is better to debate a decision without settling it than settling a decision without debating it."
—Joseph Joubert

"Multipliers love debate, and they debate with a purpose.... Multipliers aren't just debaters; they are Debate Makers."

- Ask for evidence whenever someone offers an opinion, and consider multiple data points or trends.
- Ask everyone for their inputs or at least get diverse views. Go beyond the dominant voices.
- Ask people to switch sides to consider the issue from a different viewpoint, e.g. taking an opposite stand or a different role.



5. The Investor: Instill accountability



Micromanagers vs Investors. Diminishers drive results personally while Investors build people's ability to perform without them.

- Diminishers are Micromanagers. They try to handle everything themselves. They issue instructions, then intervene thinking people can't cope without them. They create confusion by jumping in and out. People become dependent on them and can't operate in their absence.
- Multipliers are Investors. They share guidance, invest in others' success, but give back the ownership for results. They're like coaches who build a winning team without jumping in to play the game themselves.



Investors build independent teams with 3 practices:

- They establish ownership upfront. They:
 - (i) Recognize people's abilities, *name the lead* and give them full accountability.
 - (ii) Give people ownership for a *wider end-goal* that goes beyond their narrow/specific domains.
 - (iii) *Stretch the role* by getting people to go beyond their comfort zone and do things they've never done before. Set challenges at 1-2 levels above their current ability.
- After establishing ownership, they invest resources and knowledge to ensure people can deliver results. They:

KEY QUOTES

"The Diminisher is a Micromanager who jumps in and out. The Multiplier is an Investor who gives others ownership and full accountability."

*"You can jump in and teach and coach, but then you have to give the pen back...[so] your people know they are still in charge."
—Jae Choi*

"When Investors stretch the role, they stretch the person in it. This bigger role creates a vacuum that must be filled."

- (i) *Teach and coach* people so they can avoid/solve problems in the future.
- (ii) Know people will make mistakes, thus *provide backup* through other colleagues' support.
- They hold people accountable for their areas of ownership. They:
 - (i) Always *give back the accountability* after offering help, suggestions or resources.
 - (ii) *Expect completed work*, including solutions for every problem raised.
 - (iii) *Respect natural consequences* by letting people own the outcomes—be it success or failure.



To become an investor, try these 4 experiments:

- Give people 51% of the vote so they know they're in charge. Start with their current job scope then keep increasing their responsibility.
- Let nature take its course instead of jumping in to intervene. Look for teachable moments, e.g. when the team hits a snag and is looking for help. Ask good questions and focus on how they can succeed in future.
- Whenever someone raises a problem, ask for their recommended fix. Don't solve it for them.
- After offering insights or opinions, always give back the accountability.



Becoming a Multiplier



Accidental Diminishers



Most Diminishers actually have good intentions and are unaware of their diminishing impact on others. Learn to recognize these common Accidental Diminisher profiles:

KEY QUOTES

"Diminishers tell you what they know; Multipliers help you learn what you need to know."

"Multipliers never do anything for their people that their people can do for themselves."

"We judge others by their doings, but ourselves by our intentions."

- The Idea Guy is creative and innovative. He shares his ideas to stimulate others, but the team is fatigued from chasing his ideas.
- Always On leaders are dynamic and think their energy is infectious. In reality, they drain others with incessant noise.
- The Rescuer jumps in once he sees people struggling and ends up limiting others' ability to learn and grow.
- Pacesetters are achievement-oriented. They lead by example expecting others to follow, but they move too fast and others just end up watching as bystanders.
- The Rapid Responders move so quickly (to make decisions or solve problems) that others sit back and let them handle it all.
- The Optimist focuses only on the upside and doesn't recognize the problems and effort required to solve them.
- The Protectors shield their people from problems so they don't learn to fend for themselves.
- The Strategist thinks big but people end up relying on him to show the way.
- The Perfectionist strives for excellence but ends up discouraging people with his nit-picking.



All of us have our Accidental Diminisher moments. The key is to lead with intention: be aware of your natural tendencies, seek feedback from others, and overcome such tendencies using the various workarounds or experiments provided earlier. As a rule of thumb, do less and challenge more: resist jumping in to rescue others, speaking to fill the silence, or trying too hard to sell your ideas.



Dealing with Diminishers



Even if your boss is a Diminisher, you can still break the vicious cycle with a Multiplier mindset. Realize 3 things: (i) it's not necessarily about you, (ii) diminishing effects are not inevitable, and (iii) you can lead your boss.

KEY QUOTES

"As leaders, sometimes we are most helpful when we don't help."

"As leaders, sometimes the faster we run, the slower others walk."

"Sometimes a 90 percent solution executed with 100 percent ownership is better than getting it 100 percent right with a disengaged team."



Here are 3 levels of strategies for dealing with Diminishers, in increasing levels of sophistication:

- Level 1: Defensive/survival strategies to stop a downward spiral.
 - (i) Don't ignore the person (especially if it's your boss), but *turn down the volume* to reduce the impact.
 - (ii) *Build other connections* to balance their influence, e.g. have a sounding board, a cheer squad or a career network.
 - (iii) Don't fight the Diminisher head-on. *Retreat and regroup*, giving both sides the chance to exit gracefully.
 - (iv) *Send the right signals* to assure a micromanager things are under control.
 - (v) *Assert your capability* politely, e.g. "Can I try this by myself first and come back to you if I need help?"
 - (vi) *Ask for performance intel*, including a clear direction and performance feedback.
 - (vii) If all else fails, *shop for a new boss* and take the time to find the right one.
- Level 2: Offensive strategies to multiply upward or sideways.
 - (i) *Tap on your boss's strengths* instead of trying to change him/her.
 - (ii) *Proactively share* how they can best use your natural abilities.
 - (iii) *Listen to their inputs* instead of dismissing them.
 - (iv) Set the right tone by *admitting to your mistakes* and sharing what you've learned.
 - (v) Offer to *take a stretch project* beyond your existing scope.
 - (vi) Share data and *involve the Diminishers* instead of shutting them out.

KEY QUOTES

"If you do quit, don't just swap one bad manager for another. Instead of simply searching for a new job, go shopping for your next boss."

- Level 3: Strategies to inspire Multiplier leadership, i.e. help others to recognize their Diminisher tendencies so they can change.
 - (i) *Assume positive intent*, e.g. tell a Protector "I know you want to protect the team. But if you don't give them a chance to fend for themselves, they won't learn or grow stronger."
 - (ii) *Address one issue at a time* instead of overwhelming them with all the issues at once.
 - (iii) *Celebrate every progress*, no matter how small.



Putting It Into Practice

✕✓ Being a Multiplier is a matter of choice. It starts with (i) recognizing the Multipliers/Diminishers around you, (ii) recognizing the Accidental Diminisher tendencies in yourself, and (iii) making a firm decision to become a Multiplier.

⚙️ To translate Multiplier insights into results more quickly:

- Start by adopting a Multiplier mindset. Your assumptions will drive your behaviors.
- Wiseman found that most Multipliers are strong in only 2-3 of the 5 disciplines (and average for the rest). So, work the extremes by (i) mitigating your biggest weakness (your worst Diminisher tendencies), and (ii) enhancing your biggest strength (your strongest discipline).
- Choose 1 experiment to improve a Multiplier discipline or reduce an Accidental Diminisher tendency. If you're unsure where to start, ask a colleague to choose an experiment for you.
- Be prepared for setbacks, since it will take persistent effort before you can successfully make the shift to become a Multiplier.



To create a Multiplier culture, you need to address various cultural layers that affect how people think, behave and

KEY QUOTES

"Building a culture is neither a one-time injection nor a sheep dip; it requires connection to the deep layers of the culture...from surface-level cultural elements to...the deeper cultural elements."

work. This includes both visible elements (e.g. shared language/behavior) and subtler elements (e.g. rituals, norms and beliefs):

Cultural Elements	Multiplier Practices
<i>Common language:</i> Words or phrases with a shared meaning	• Get the team to read this <i>book</i> and discuss it. • Get people to take the <i>Accidental Diminisher</i> quiz and discuss their self-assessments.
<i>Learned behaviors:</i> A set of learned responses to certain stimuli	• Explain <i>Multiplier mindsets</i> to spark internal dialogue. • Teach <i>Multiplier skills/practices</i> with 360° assessments to help leaders identify and monitor areas for improvement. • Use simulations to let people apply the insights in <i>daily decisions</i>.
<i>Shared beliefs:</i> What's accepted as the "truth"	• Have a <i>leadership ethos</i> to make your Multiplier beliefs explicit.
<i>Heroes and legends:</i> Stories about heroic actions or people who're admired/idealized	• Create internal heroes by <i>shining a spotlight</i> on Multiplier examples/moments. • Use <i>measurements</i> to assess how far managers are displaying Multiplier behaviors.
<i>Rituals and norms:</i> Consistent behaviors followed by an individual or group	• Pilot a <i>Multiplier practice</i> in a small group before implementing it organization-wide. • Link Multiplier behaviors to <i>business metrics and KPIs</i>.

KEY QUOTES

"Unlocking individual potential is not just a matter of personal will and individual behavior change; it is a function of entire systems, and reshaping collective will is hard work."

"Make heroes out of these genius makers who bring out the best in others."



Other Details in the Book to Look out For

This is a comprehensive guidebook with numerous real-life examples for each set of Multiplier and Diminisher characteristics. The book also includes several appendices with additional information on the research process, commonly asked questions, team discussions and the various Multiplier experiments outlined in this summary. For more details and resources, please visit thewisemangroup.com.